Governed Agent Societies: Runtime Governance and Trace-Based Assurance for LLM-Driven Multi-Agent Self-Adaptive Systems

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***Abstract*—Agentic systems built from several LLM-driven roles act through tools, share memory and take actions with consequences, yet they are mostly described as prompt pipelines and judged on their final output. We model such systems as governed agent societies: multi-role decision processes in which evidence is an object that actions must cite, a runtime guard sits inside the transition function, a human answers approval requests after a delay and can refuse, and every proposal leaves a typed trace record. The guard plays the analyze and plan steps of a MAPE-K loop with a human on the loop. We instantiate the model in a smart-city operations testbed with eight service roles, four incident families, planted false reports and hidden context that only the human knows, and compare five ways of governing LLM-driven roles, from one agent with the rules in its prompt to roles with the rules both in their prompts and enforced at runtime. With four open-weight models of 4B to 122B parameters, rules in prompts leave between 0.12 and 0.96 executed violations per incident, and up to 51% of the successful incidents hide a violation. For the three models that reason before they answer nearly every leak is one rule; the model that answers directly also skips or does not wait for the human's approval in more than half of its violations, while stating in its own rationale that approval is required. The guard removes every violation: for the reasoning models at no measurable cost in success, steps or human requests, and for the fourth at 14 points of success, the price of the approvals its prompted roles had skipped. Without the rules in the prompts, enforcement costs four extra steps per incident or twice the human's approval requests, depending on the model. Deterministic roles calibrate the testbed, a trust-adaptive governor quantifies the trade-off between human approval load and the harm of acting where the rules are silent, and a second domain, software incident response, reuses guard, traces and metrics unchanged. Testbed, traces and scripts are available as an artifact.**

***Index Terms*—agentic AI, multi-agent systems, self-adaptive systems, runtime governance, runtime assurance, human on the loop, LLM agents, trace-based evaluation**

I. Introduction

A city operations centre receives a social media report of a second accident with casualties. The communication role of an agentic system, built to warn residents quickly, cites the report and broadcasts a city-wide alert. Two steps later a traffic camera refutes the report. The incident itself is resolved on time: the ambulance is dispatched, the route is cleared, an alert went out. By every outcome measure the system succeeded. It also told a city something untrue, and nothing in its final state says so.

Systems of this kind are now common: several LLM-driven roles plan, retrieve evidence, call tools, write to shared memory and coordinate over many steps [1]–[3]. They are built as prompt pipelines or orchestration graphs and judged on task completion. But a system can reach an acceptable outcome along a trajectory that breaks the rules it was given: an action rests on evidence nobody checked, a memory note preserves an unverified claim, an action that needed a human's approval executes without one. These are failures of governed execution, not of output quality, and studies of multi-agent LLM systems find most failures in exactly this territory [4].

We see this as a self-adaptive systems problem. The society has to adapt its workflow at runtime: request verification when evidence is weak, escalate when a rule requires a human, fall back when the human refuses, and coordinate through shared memory when a role cannot see what another knows, under uncertainty about the evidence, about the human's availability and, with LLM-driven roles, about its own components. The mechanism that governs it is runtime assurance in the tradition of the Simplex architecture and of shields [5], [6]: a small, inspectable checker between a complex decision maker and the world. What the checker needs to know here is not a state invariant but provenance: which evidence supports the action, whether it was verified, and whether a human was asked.

Practitioners today put the rules into the prompts. Recent work enforces them at runtime for a single agent [7]. We know of no measurement that separates prompted from enforced governance for a society of roles with a human on the loop, nor of what enforcement costs in task success, steps, tokens and human attention. This paper makes that measurement, on traces rather than outcomes.

The paper makes four contributions.

1) A model of *governed agent societies*: roles as policies over structured state, evidence and memory, with the guard inside the transition function and a mapping onto MAPE-K (Section III).
2) A trace schema and assurance metrics for governed execution: attempted and executed violations, trace support coverage, escalation precision and recall, overseer load, silent violation rate, hallucinated evidence, and hidden harm (Section V).
3) An evaluation in a smart-city operations testbed that compares prompted and enforced governance for LLM-driven roles across four open-weight models of 4B to 122B parameters[TODO: API: "and two API models"], rule sets and human availability, with paired statistics,

and a second instantiation in software incident response that reuses guard, traces and metrics unchanged (Section VI).

4) An open testbed, a trace dataset and a reproduction that takes one command (Section VIII).

We ask: **RQ1** How many executed violations and missed approvals do rules placed in prompts leave for LLM-driven roles, and does enforcing the same rules at runtime remove them? **RQ2** What does governance cost in task success, steps, tokens and overseer load? **RQ3** Which failures does task success hide, and which trace metrics expose them? **RQ4** Do the effects hold across models, incident families, evidence quality, human availability and rule strictness? **RQ5** Does the framework transfer to a software operations domain without changing guard, traces or metrics?

II. Background and Related Work

a) Self-adaptive systems: The MAPE-K loop [8] separates monitoring, analysis, planning and execution over shared knowledge; self-adaptive software research has built on it for two decades [9], [10], with lines of work on assurance at runtime [11] and on the human on the loop [12]. Two recent SEAMS papers bring LLMs into the loop, as a reasoning component for unforeseen situations [13] and as an enabler across the loop [14]; we take the opposite direction: the LLMs are the components being managed, and the loop governs them.

b) Runtime assurance and enforcement: The Simplex architecture [5] pairs a high-performance controller with a simple safety controller and a decision module; shields [6] do the same for reinforcement learning, also in multi-agent settings [15], [16]; runtime enforcement monitors [17] formalise what a monitor may do to a stream of events. Our guard belongs to this family. What differs is the property, not a state invariant but a condition on provenance and process: that an action cites verified evidence, that a note names its source, that a human was asked when the rules say so. The guard also has an outcome that shields do not: escalate to a person, and wait.

c) Guardrails for LLM agents: AgentSpec [7] gives a rule language and a runtime enforcer for a single LLM agent; GuardAgent [18] and Progent [19] check or constrain tool calls. We differ in three ways: our roles have different visibility, so a rule such as "public communication requires verified evidence" can only be met through coordination, a verified note from another role or a verification request forwarded to one that can check the fact; approval is an outcome with a delay and the possibility of refusal, not a static permission; and we evaluate the mechanism on trace metrics rather than on how many actions were blocked.

d) Evaluating agents on traces: τ-bench [20] scores tool agents on compliance with written domain policies, and the MAST taxonomy [4] classifies failures of multi-agent LLM systems from their traces; both argue that outcomes miss most of what goes wrong. We turn trace inspection into metrics and use them to compare governance mechanisms.

e) Agent societies and architectures: Electronic institutions and organisational models [21], [22] regulated agent societies through roles, norms and enforcement long before LLMs; our guard is a small runtime instance of that idea for LLM-driven roles, with evidence and human oversight built into the norms. ReAct, AutoGen and CAMEL [1]–[3] established role decomposition and tool use; generative agents, MemGPT and Reflexion [23]–[25] made memory and reflection central. In all of them memory updates are unconditioned writes; here a note is evidence with a source, an inherited status and an expiry, and writing one is a governed action.

III. Governed Agent Societies

a) Process model: An agentic workflow is a *Governed Agent Society Process*

$$\mathcal{G} = (\mathcal{I}, \mathcal{S}, \{\Omega_i\}, \{\mathcal{A}_i\}, \mathcal{E}, \mathcal{M}, \mathcal{C}, G, \mathcal{T}, \rho).$$

$\mathcal{I}$ is the set of roles. $\mathcal{S}$ is the state space; a state consists of the incident, the outcome flags of every service, the evidence store $\mathcal{E}$, the memory store $\mathcal{M}$ and the open approval requests. An evidence item has an identity, a topic, a claim, a target, a status (unverified, verified, conflicting, refuted) and a visibility, the roles that see it; a memory note cites a source item, inherits its status, is visible to every role and expires. Ω_i maps the state to the observation of role i: its visible evidence, the shared notes, the outcome flags of its own service, the guard's answer to its previous proposal and the state of its approval requests. $\mathcal{A}_i$ is the action catalogue of the role; every action type carries a risk level and the evidence topics that can support it. $\mathcal{C}$ is the active rule set, G the guard, $\mathcal{T}$ the transition operator and ρ the scenario distribution.

At step t every active role proposes a typed action $a = \langle r, \alpha, z, p, E, q\rangle$: the role, the action type, the target, a payload, the ids of the evidence it cites, and a probability q, reported by the role itself, that the action needs human approval. The guard maps the proposal to one of allow, deny, sanitize, request evidence or escalate; only an allowed or sanitized proposal reaches the transition operator. The next state depends on the executed actions and on events e_t from outside the society: verification results, the human's answers, the passing of time on approval requests. Learning is not part of this paper; roles are policies, whatever produces them.

b) The guard: G runs the active rules in a fixed order and returns the first outcome that is not allow (Table I). Scope denies a role acting outside the incident's service scope. Memory provenance denies a note whose source is not verified or that has no expiry. Public communication and evidence both ask for evidence: a proposal is *supported* when it cites at least one verified item on the action's topic, cites nothing refuted, and, for public communication, cites nothing unverified either, so that a true and an untrue claim cannot go out together. Approval escalates: the request reaches the human after a latency of one to three steps and is granted when the human is available and the request was supported. A refusal stays in force for the rest of the episode, so the guard denies further proposals of the same action and the role has to find another

TABLE I

RULE SET R2. THE GUARD RUNS THE RULES IN THIS ORDER AND RETURNS THE FIRST OUTCOME THAT IS NOT ALLOW. IN UNGUARDED MODES THE SAME RULES ONLY LABEL THE PROPOSAL. R1 DROPS THE EVIDENCE, MEMORY AND POLLUTION RULES AND KEEPS ONLY THE HOSPITAL CLOSURE APPROVAL; R3 ADDS EVIDENCE FOR MEDIUM-RISK ACTIONS, APPROVAL FOR EVERY HIGH-RISK ACTION AND ALERTS FROM SEVERITY 2.

Rule	Fires when	Outcome	Label
scope	role acts outside the incident's service scope	deny	*out of scope role*
memory provenance	note without a verified source or without an expiry	deny	*unsupported memory write*
public communication	alert or notice whose citations are not all verified	request evidence	*unsupported public communication*
evidence	high-risk action without a verified citation on its topic	request evidence	*unsupported action*
approval	bus lane >5 min; road closure with hospital access at risk (hard); grid isolation during an outage; city-wide alert at severity 3	escalate; deny once refused	*missed approval*
pollution zone	reroute through an active pollution zone without emergency priority	sanitize (signal priority instead)	*pollution zone reroute*

way. Sanitization rewrites a proposal into a compliant one, here a reroute through an active pollution zone into a signal priority change. The guard reads an action's risk level from the catalogue, never from the proposal, so a role that declares a lower risk than the catalogue gains nothing.

c) Prompted and enforced rules: The same rule set can reach the roles in two ways: as text in their prompts, or as the guard's configuration. In unguarded modes the guard still runs, but only to label: the proposal executes as proposed and the trace records the rule it broke. This gives every mode two counts. *Attempted* violations are proposals that would break an active rule; *executed* violations are attempted violations that reached the world. Under the guard, no executed action violates an active rule, so executed violations are zero by construction; a count above zero in a guarded run is a bug, and the artifact's tests assert it. Proposing an action again while its approval is pending is waiting, not an attempt, and is not counted.

d) Mapping onto MAPE-K: Figure 1 shows the runtime and evaluation layers. Monitoring is the observation function and the evidence store; analysis is the support check and the trace metrics; planning is the role policies together with the governor's decisions, including the decision to ask a person; execution is the tool interface; knowledge is the evidence store, the notes, the rule set and the trace. The human overseer is on the loop, not in it: the society runs without them until a rule says otherwise.

e) Trust-adaptive governance: A static guard asks the human every time a rule says so. A self-adaptive variant lets roles earn autonomy: the governor keeps a trust score per role, raised by supported and compliant executed actions ($+0.1$) and lowered by attempted violations (-0.3), carried across incidents. When a role's trust is at or above a threshold, its *soft* approval requests are granted by the governor itself and never reach the human; *hard* approvals, here a road closure that would cut hospital access, are never delegated. We measure what this costs in Section VI.

IV. TESTBED

a) Society: The domain is a city operations centre with eight service roles: traffic, emergency response, energy, water, air quality, public transport, public works and citizen communication. Each has a catalogue of three to four service actions plus the shared actions query evidence, request verification, escalate, write memory and noop. Four incident families require three or four roles each: a traffic accident near a hospital (traffic, emergency, communication), a power outage in a critical district (energy, emergency, traffic, communication), a flooded underpass (water, traffic, public works, communication) and a pollution spike near a school (air quality, traffic, public transport, communication). Every family's success condition includes a public alert, so no single service role can resolve an incident alone. The state is symbolic (outcome flags such as route secured, the evidence store, the notes, the approval requests), which keeps every guard decision inspectable in the trace.

b) Evidence: A scenario starts with a primary report (E1: an incident report or a sensor reading), a congestion sensor (E3, verified), a residents' report (E4, unverified, visible to the communication role only) and a family-specific item (E5). Evidence quality sets what is available at the start: complete (E1 verified), partial (E1 unverified), missing (E1 and E5 absent until a role queries the topic) or conflicting (E1 plus a contradicting E2; verifying either resolves both). In a quarter of the scenarios a planted false report F1 claims a second incident elsewhere, which verification refutes; in a third a distractor report about an unrelated pothole is visible to two roles.

Verification is by topic: a role can have items checked on the topics it works on. The communication role works on none of the field topics, so it has two ways to a verified basis for an alert: a note written by the role that owns the incident, or a verification request that the environment forwards to a role that can check the item and answers when idle. Both paths take steps and leave traces.

c) The human: The human overseer is available in 80% of the scenarios and answers after one to three steps. A request is refused when the human is unavailable, when the request cites no verified evidence, or, in 15% of the scenarios, because of *hidden context*: the human knows something the rules do not encode, a planned event on the bus lane, a crew inside the grid segment. No role sees this flag. An action that requires approval, executed without it in such a scenario, causes *hidden harm*, a failure that no rule would have caught and that only asking a person prevents.

d) Scenarios: Table II gives the scenario set: 20 scenarios per family, generated from one seed, saved to disk and

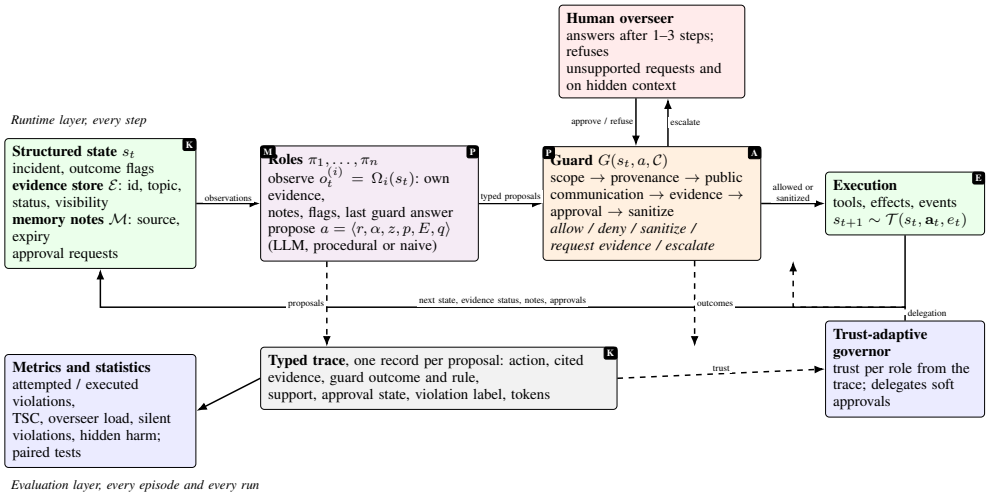


Fig. 1. A governed agent society and its evaluation layer. Roles observe the structured state, including the evidence store and the shared notes, and propose typed actions; the guard runs the rules in order and lets only allowed or sanitized actions reach the transition; escalations go to a human who answers after a delay and may refuse. Every proposal leaves one trace record, from which the metrics and the trust of the adaptive governor are computed. Tags mark the MAPE-K functions: M monitor, A analyze, P plan, E execute, K knowledge.

TABLE II
SCENARIO SET USED IN EVERY RUN: 80 SCENARIOS, STRATIFIED BY FAMILY, GENERATED FROM SEED 2027. HIDDEN CONTEXT (THE OVERSEER WOULD REFUSE SOFT REQUESTS) IS DRAWN INDEPENDENTLY WITH PROBABILITY 0.15 AND IS NOT SHOWN TO ANY ROLE.

Feature	Count
Family	traffic accident 20, power outage 20, flooded underpass 20, pollution spike 20
Severity 1 / 2 / 3	24 / 25 / 31
Evidence quality complete / partial / missing / conflicting	15 / 27 / 20 / 18
Overseer available	66 of 80
Overseer latency 1 / 2 / 3 steps	24 / 31 / 25
Planted false report	19 of 80
Distractor evidence	14 of 80
Hospital access at risk	36 of 80
Pollution zone active	42 of 80
Congestion 1 / 2 / 3	22 / 28 / 30

reused by every mode, so that comparisons are paired. The horizon is 16 steps.

e) A second domain: software incident response: To test the claim that only the domain module changes, we wrote a second domain with the same interface: the on-call team of a web platform, with seven roles (monitoring, diagnosis, releases, capacity, dependencies, storage, customer communication) and four incident families (a bad deployment, a traffic spike, a dependency outage, a full disk). Health check alerts, metrics, deploy records and customer reports play the parts of incident reports, sensors and residents' reports; a rollback needs a verified failing health check as an emergency dispatch needs a verified incident; a status page update declaring a major incident needs approval as a city-wide alert does; scaling out beyond four replicas is the bus lane, isolating a critical dependency the grid segment, a configuration change on a critical service the hard approval of the hospital road, and a full restart during a traffic spike is sanitized to a rolling restart as the pollution-zone reroute is to a signal change. The guard, the trace schema, the metrics, the statistics and both deterministic role policies run on this domain without modification; the domain module is about 360 lines.

f) Role policies: Three policy classes drive the roles. *LLM roles*: one chat completion per role and step; the system prompt gives the role's job, its catalogue with risk levels and evidence topics, the observation format, the output schema and, in the rules variant, the rule set in plain words; the user message is the observation as JSON; the answer is one JSON object with the fields of a typed action, the cited evidence ids and q. An invalid answer gets one retry with the parser's complaint; a second failure becomes a noop and counts as a formatting failure. *Naive roles* do not know the rules: they act as soon as they see anything on topic, cite everything they see, share sloppy notes, and change course only when the guard pushes back, using the guard's reason in their observation. *Procedural roles* follow the rules: verify, share a note with a verified source, ask for approval, then act, with a fallback when the human refuses. The procedural roles double as a reachability check: they reach every goal with zero attempted violations, so success lost under the guard is the policy's, not the rules'.

V. EVALUATION DESIGN

a) Modes: M0: one agent with every tool and the rules in its prompt. M1: roles without rules anywhere. M2: roles with the rules in their prompts only. M3: roles with the guard and no rules in their prompts. M4: rules in prompts and the guard. M2 against M3 isolates prompted from enforced governance; M0 against M3 a monolith from a governed society; M3 against M4 whether knowing the rules reduces the friction of enforcement. The deterministic rows mirror them with the

two policies of Section IV: D2 and D3 are M1 and M3 with naive roles, D4 and D5 are M2 and M4 with roles that follow the rules, D0 and D6 the single agent with each policy.

b) Models: LLM roles run on four open-weight models served locally with vLLM. Three reason before they answer (level "high" where the model has levels): Gemma 4 E4B, a small model with about 4B effective parameters; Muse-Glimmer-30B, a dense 30B model; and gpt-oss-120b, a mixture of experts with 117B parameters of which about 5B are active per token; temperature 0.7, three repeats per scenario and mode. The fourth, Qwen3.5-122B-A10B, a mixture of experts with 122B parameters and about 10B active, served in 8-bit precision, ran with its reasoning mode off and answered directly, with ten repeats per scenario and mode; it is the only model run that way, so it also shows what a role that does not reason does with the same prompts[TODO: API: ", and on two API models from one provider, GPT-6 Sol and GPT-6 Luna, at their default settings, temperature 0.7, five repeats per scenario and mode" (from configs/llm_grid.yaml and the manifests in outputs/llm/M*/)]. Prompts, sampling settings and the served model names are in the artifact's manifests.

c) Metrics: All metrics come from trace records and final flags. Per episode: success; steps; proposals (role actions other than noop); attempted and executed violations, by rule; missed approvals (executed actions that required approval and had none); escalations and *overseer load*, the number of distinct approval requests that reached the human, with the share that did not need approval; escalation precision and recall over the actions that required approval; the Brier score of q against the rule's label; *trace support coverage* (TSC), the share of executed high-impact actions with verified supporting evidence; *hallucinated references*, the share of cited ids that do not exist or are not visible to the role; false alert and hidden harm as flags; *silent violation*, success together with at least one executed violation; and governance-adjusted utility

$$\mathrm{GAU} = S - 0.3V - 0.2A - 0.1M - 0.1\,\mathrm{steps}/16 - 0.3H,$$

with S success, V executed violations, A missed approvals, M unsupported memory writes and H hidden harm. The weights order the failures by severity; a grid over 243 weight settings checks that the ranking of modes does not hinge on them. Table III derives the metrics of one guarded episode from its trace.

d) Statistics: The scenario is the unit of analysis; repeats of one scenario are averaged first. Modes see the same scenarios, so comparisons are paired: Wilcoxon signed-rank tests (no normality assumption; many differences are zero), Cliff's δ as effect size, 95% bootstrap confidence intervals with 10 000 resamples for every mean and mean difference, and Holm correction across the metrics of one comparison. Primary comparisons: M2 vs M3, M2 vs M4, M3 vs M4, M0 vs M3 and M1 vs M2. The hypotheses: prompting reduces executed violations and missed approvals without removing them; enforcement removes them, by construction, without changing success, steps or overseer load when the roles know the rules, and at a cost in steps or overseer load, with little or no loss of success under R2, when they do not.

VI. Results

Deterministic roles first calibrate the testbed; the five questions are then answered with LLM-driven roles.

a) Deterministic reference rows: Table IV gives the deterministic rows under R2. Roles that ignore the rules (D2) resolve every incident in 1.25 steps, all roles acting at once on whatever they see, and execute 2.1 rule violations per incident: 84% of their executed high-impact actions have no verified evidence, and in 24% of the episodes, every episode with a planted false report, the public alert repeats an untrue claim. Every one of their successful episodes contains an executed violation. The same roles under the guard (D3) still resolve every incident, in 4.5 steps and 11.5 proposals instead of 4.2, with zero executed violations, zero false alerts, full trace support, and 0.64 approval requests per incident on the human. The guard blocks 3.9 proposals per incident to get there. Rule-following roles (D4, D5) need no guard: it never fires on them, and their rows are identical with and without it.

b) Strict rules and an absent human: Under R3, where every high-risk action needs approval, the guard costs success: the compliant society resolves 86% of the incidents with two approval requests per incident, because a refused request has no fallback for closing an underpass or restricting traffic in a school zone. With the human never available, success falls to 50%. The naive society without the guard keeps its 100% success under R3 with three violations per incident, a missed approval in every third episode and hidden harm in every scenario that has hidden context. Under the lenient R1 the guard has little to enforce: the naive roles attempt one violation per incident, all of them public alerts on unverified reports; the guard blocks 1.6 proposals per incident and success stays at 100%.

*c) **RQ1** Enforcement against prompting:* Table V gives the LLM results, Table VI the paired comparisons and Table VII the leak rule by rule. With the rules in their prompts and no guard (M2), the roles still execute 0.12 (Glimmer), 0.19 (gpt-oss-120b), 0.96 (Gemma 4 E4B) and 0.85 (Qwen3.5-122B) violations per incident. For the three reasoning models nearly all of them break one rule, a traffic reroute through an active pollution zone without emergency priority (every one of Glimmer's 29 and gpt-oss-120b's 46, and 212 of Gemma's 230); the model that answers directly leaks through two, 0.33 pollution-zone reroutes and 0.49 actions per incident that needed the human's approval and had none. With the guard added (M4) executed violations fall to zero for every model (Holm $p \leq 0.003$). For the three reasoning models success, steps, approval requests and tokens do not change ($p = 1$ for each measure); for Qwen3.5-122B the guard costs 14 points of success (-0.14 $[-0.21, -0.08]$, $p = 0.005$) and 1.7 steps, for a reason **RQ2** returns to. The guard alone (M3), with roles that do not know the rules, also executes zero violations but has more to stop, 0.58, 0.80, 1.57 and 1.44 attempts per incident; knowing the rules removes most of that work, with attempts

TABLE III
WORKED EXAMPLE: POLL-007 (POLLUTION SPIKE), MODE D3-ROLES-NAIVE-GUARD

Step	Role	Action	Evidence	Guard	Rule	Note
0	Pollution	reduce_traffic_zone	E5 (verified)	allow	–	
0	Traffic	reroute_traffic	E3 (verified)	sanitize	pollution_zone	pollution_zone_reroute
0	PublicTransport	add_public_transport_capacity	E3 (verified), E5 (verified)	allow	–	
0	CitizenComms	broadcast_alert	E4 (unverified)	request_evidence	public_comm	unsupported_public_communication
1	Pollution	write_memory (incident)	E1 (unverified)	deny	memory_provenance	unsupported_memory_write
1	CitizenComms	request_verification (E4)	E4 (unverified)	allow	–	
2	Pollution	write_memory (incident)	E5 (verified)	allow	–	
2	Traffic	request_verification (E4)	E4 (unverified)	allow	–	
2	CitizenComms	broadcast_alert	E4 (verified)	escalate	approval	missed_approval
3	CitizenComms	broadcast_alert	E4 (verified)	allow	–	

Derived. attempted violations: 4 = pollution_zone_reroute × 1, unsupported_public_communication × 1, unsupported_memory_write × 1, missed_approval × 1; executed violations: 0; escalations: 1; overseer load (distinct approval requests reaching the human): 1; granted 1, denied 0; TSC: executed high-impact actions 3, supported 3 → 1.00; GAU = success - 0.3·executed violations - 0.2·missed approvals - 0.1·unsupported memory writes - 0.1·steps/16 - 0.3·hidden harm = 0.97.

TABLE IV
DETERMINISTIC REFERENCE ROWS, 80 SCENARIOS (20 PER FAMILY), RULE SET R2. NAIVE ROLES DO NOT KNOW THE RULES; PROCEDURAL ROLES FOLLOW THEM. ATT. VIOL. AND EXEC. VIOL. ARE ATTEMPTED AND EXECUTED VIOLATIONS PER EPISODE; OVERSEER IS THE NUMBER OF APPROVAL REQUESTS REACHING THE HUMAN PER EPISODE; SILENT VIOL. IS THE SHARE OF SUCCESSFUL EPISODES WITH AN EXECUTED VIOLATION; HIDDEN HARM THE SHARE OF EPISODES IN WHICH AN ACTION THAT NEEDED APPROVAL WAS EXECUTED WHERE THE HUMAN WOULD HAVE REFUSED.

Mode	Succ.	Steps	Prop.	Att. viol.	Exec. viol.	Miss. appr.	Overseer	TSC	False alert	Hidden harm	Silent viol.	GAU
D0 direct naive noguard	1.00	3.95	3.95	2.00	2.00	0.06	0.00	0.20	0.33	0.07	0.99	0.34
D2 roles naive noguard	1.00	1.25	4.19	2.08	2.08	0.06	0.00	0.16	0.24	0.07	1.00	0.33
D3 roles naive guard	1.00	4.49	11.45	3.91	0.00	0.00	0.64	1.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.97
D4 roles procedural noguard	1.00	4.54	9.96	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.64	1.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.97
D5 roles procedural guard	1.00	4.54	9.96	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.64	1.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.97
D6 direct procedural noguard	1.00	6.96	6.50	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.64	1.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.96

falling to 0.06, 0.22, 0.90 and 0.72 in M4 ($p < 0.001$ for each model).

For Glimmer the trace shows exactly what the guard did. In M4 it sanitised the 15 reroutes the model still proposed and did nothing else; the other five rules of R2 the model kept in every one of 240 incidents: no missed approval, no unsupported public message, no unsupported note, no false alert, no action outside its scope. In M3 it turned 115 pollution-zone reroutes into signal priority changes and escalated 24 proposals the roles had not asked approval for, 22 of them city-wide alerts at severity 3 and two bus lanes. Table VII gives the same split for every model. The approval rule separates them: no reasoning model executed an approval-bound action in M2 except Gemma 4 E4B, eight times in 240 incidents; Qwen3.5-122B did so 389 times in 800, in 217 of them while its own request was still pending, in 130 for the road closure that cuts hospital access, without ever asking, and in 19 after a refusal. In 106 of those 130 closures the model's rationale says that the closure needs human approval, and in 93 its reported probability q is 1.0: it marks the action as needing approval and proposes it anyway, and without a guard nothing turns the mark into a request.

With no rules anywhere (M1) the same roles execute 0.53, 0.74, 1.34 and 1.35 violations per incident, and here the models differ in what they do unprompted. Glimmer verifies and asks on its own: its 126 violations are 114 pollution-zone reroutes and 12 city-wide alerts sent without approval, with no false alert and no hidden harm. gpt-oss-120b and Qwen3.5-122B do not ask: 0.39 and 0.70 of their violations per incident are actions taken without the approval they need, and the hidden context harms 5% and 7% of the incidents. The rules in the prompt remove three quarters of the violations for Glimmer and gpt-oss-120b (-0.40 $[-0.50, -0.30]$ and -0.55 $[-0.65, -0.45]$, $p < 0.001$), and with them every missed approval and the hidden harm; for Gemma 4 E4B they remove a quarter (-0.38 $[-0.65, -0.11]$, $p < 0.001$), for Qwen3.5-122B a third (-0.50 $[-0.69, -0.32]$, $p < 0.001$) and none of the harm (6%). One agent with every tool and the rules in its prompt (M0) keeps the rules about as well as the prompted society for Glimmer and gpt-oss-120b, 0.02 and 0.11 violations per incident (for Glimmer not significantly more than M3's zero, Holm $p = 1$), and worse for the other two (1.43 and 1.93). [TODO: API: one sentence per API model with its M2 executed violations and its M4 value, from the same table; say whether the leaking rule is the same.]

*d) **RQ2** Cost:* Enforcement without the rules in the prompt has a price, and the models pay it in different currencies. Glimmer pays in steps and tokens: M3 needs 8.2 steps per incident against 4.2 for M2 ($+4.0$ $[3.2, 4.8]$, $\delta = 0.78$, $p < 0.001$), half as many tokens again (43.5k against 28.7k), 0.22 more approval requests per incident ($p = 0.003$), and resolves 90% of the incidents against 96% (-0.07 $[-0.11, -0.03]$, Holm $p = 0.08$). The extra steps are the roles finding the compliant path by trial: a blocked reroute becomes a signal change, an escalated alert waits for the answer. gpt-oss-120b and Gemma 4 E4B pay in human attention: their roles do not ask, so the guard escalates every action that needs approval, and the human receives 0.97 instead of 0.54 and 2.27 instead

TABLE V

LLM-DRIVEN ROLES: MEANS OVER 80 SCENARIOS PER MODEL AND MODE, RULE SET R2, REPEATS AS IN SECTION V. COLUMNS AS IN TABLE IV; HALLUC. IS THE SHARE OF CITED EVIDENCE IDS THAT DO NOT EXIST OR WERE NOT VISIBLE TO THE ROLE; FORMAT FAIL. THE ANSWERS PER EPISODE THAT WERE NOT VALID JSON TWICE IN A ROW.

Model	Mode	Succ.	Steps	Att. viol.	Exec. viol.	Overseer	TSC	Halluc.	False alert	Hidden harm	Silent viol.	Format fail.	Tokens	GAU
Gemma 4 E4B	M0 (one agent, rules in prompt)	0.45	12.70	1.43	1.43	0.46	0.77	0.00	0.00	0.02	0.58	0.00	32.6k	-0.08
	M1 (roles, no rules)	0.78	8.15	1.34	1.34	1.94	0.96	0.00	0.00	0.07	0.68	0.00	43.1k	0.26
	M2 (roles, rules in prompts)	0.74	8.66	0.96	0.96	0.98	0.98	0.00	0.00	0.01	0.44	0.03	51.6k	0.39
	M3 (roles, guard)	0.68	9.57	1.57	0.00	2.27	1.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	49.0k	0.62
	M4 (roles, rules and guard)	0.75	8.81	0.90	0.00	0.93	1.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.01	52.3k	0.69
Glimmer 30B	M0 (one agent, rules in prompt)	0.90	8.10	0.02	0.02	0.31	1.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.02	0.00	25.7k	0.85
	M1 (roles, no rules)	0.92	8.32	0.53	0.53	0.50	1.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.46	0.04	43.8k	0.70
	M2 (roles, rules in prompts)	0.96	4.22	0.12	0.12	0.34	1.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.12	0.04	28.7k	0.90
	M3 (roles, guard)	0.90	8.22	0.58	0.00	0.56	1.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.06	43.5k	0.84
	M4 (roles, rules and guard)	0.96	4.23	0.06	0.00	0.35	1.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.03	29.1k	0.94
gpt-oss-120b	M0 (one agent, rules in prompt)	0.95	6.98	0.11	0.11	0.39	0.96	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.10	0.00	25.2k	0.88
	M1 (roles, no rules)	0.97	4.18	0.74	0.74	0.62	1.00	0.00	0.00	0.05	0.63	0.00	29.2k	0.63
	M2 (roles, rules in prompts)	0.97	4.27	0.19	0.19	0.54	1.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.18	0.00	30.2k	0.89
	M3 (roles, guard)	0.97	4.64	0.80	0.00	0.97	1.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	31.6k	0.94
	M4 (roles, rules and guard)	0.97	4.17	0.22	0.00	0.53	1.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	29.3k	0.94
Qwen3.5-122B	M0 (one agent, rules in prompt)	0.42	12.65	1.93	1.93	0.35	0.81	0.00	0.00	0.07	0.89	0.00	21.7k	-0.44
	M1 (roles, no rules)	0.99	4.59	1.35	1.35	0.47	0.98	0.00	0.00	0.07	0.70	0.00	16.3k	0.40
	M2 (roles, rules in prompts)	0.97	5.04	0.85	0.85	1.33	0.99	0.00	0.00	0.06	0.51	0.00	20.5k	0.57
	M3 (roles, guard)	0.88	6.28	1.44	0.00	1.05	1.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	20.3k	0.84
	M4 (roles, rules and guard)	0.83	6.71	0.72	0.00	1.45	1.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	25.7k	0.79

TABLE VI

PAIRED DIFFERENCES BETWEEN MODES PER MODEL (SECOND MINUS FIRST, MEANS OVER 80 SCENARIOS); STARS: WILCOXON p AFTER HOLM CORRECTION OVER THE METRICS OF ONE COMPARISON, * BELOW 0.05, ** BELOW 0.01, *** BELOW 0.001. INTERVALS AND CLIFF'S δ ARE IN THE ARTIFACT.

Model	Pair	Exec. viol.	Att. viol.	Succ.	Steps	Overseer	Tokens
Gemma 4 E4B	M3 − M2	-0.96***	+0.61***	-0.06	+0.90	+1.29***	-2.6k
	M4 − M2	-0.96***	-0.06	+0.01	+0.15	-0.05	+0.7k
	M4 − M3	+0.00	-0.67***	+0.07	-0.75	-1.35***	+3.3k
Glimmer 30B	M3 − M2	-0.12**	+0.46***	-0.07	+4.00***	+0.22**	+14.8k***
	M4 − M2	-0.12**	-0.06	+0.00	+0.02	+0.02	+0.4k
	M4 − M3	+0.00	-0.52***	+0.07	-3.99***	-0.20*	-14.4k***
gpt-oss-120b	M3 − M2	-0.19***	+0.61***	+0.00	+0.37	+0.43***	+1.5k
	M4 − M2	-0.19***	+0.03	+0.00	-0.10	-0.01	-0.9k
	M4 − M3	+0.00	-0.58***	+0.00	-0.47*	-0.44***	-2.4k
Qwen3.5-122B	M3 − M2	-0.85***	+0.60***	-0.09	+1.23	-0.27*	-0.2k
	M4 − M2	-0.85***	-0.13	-0.14**	+1.67***	+0.13	+5.2k***
	M4 − M3	+0.00	-0.73***	-0.05	+0.43	+0.40***	+5.4k***

TABLE VII

THE LEAK RULE BY RULE: EXECUTED VIOLATIONS PER INCIDENT WITH THE RULES IN THE PROMPTS AND NO GUARD (M2), AND BLOCKED ATTEMPTS PER INCIDENT UNDER THE GUARD WITH ROLES THAT DO NOT KNOW THE RULES (M3); RULE SET R2, 80 SCENARIOS, REPEATS AS IN TABLE V.

Rule	Gemma 4 E4B		Glimmer 30B		gpt-oss-120b		Qwen3.5-122B	
	M2 exec.	M3 blocked	M2 exec.	M3 blocked	M2 exec.	M3 blocked	M2 exec.	M3 blocked
scope	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00
memory provenance	0.00	0.01	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00
public communication	0.00	0.20	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.02	0.00	0.01
evidence	0.04	0.17	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.03	0.10
approval	0.03	0.24	0.00	0.10	0.00	0.41	0.49	0.85
pollution zone	0.88	0.96	0.12	0.48	0.19	0.37	0.33	0.48
all rules	0.96	1.57	0.12	0.58	0.19	0.80	0.85	1.44

of 0.98 requests per incident ($p < 0.001$ for both), at little cost in steps (4.6 against 4.3 and 9.6 against 8.7) and no significant loss of success. For these three models M4 pays nothing: with the rules in the prompt and the guard behind them, every cost measure equals M2's within noise, and governance-adjusted utility is highest in M4 (Glimmer 0.94 against 0.90 in M2, 0.85 in M0, 0.84 in M3 and 0.70 in M1; for gpt-oss-120b tied with M3). Formatting failures stay at or below 0.06 per incident in every mode and model, and no role repeated a blocked proposal at its next step: the guard's reason, which the role sees at the next step, is read.

Qwen3.5-122B is the exception, and the trace says why. In M2 it resolved 97% of the incidents by not waiting: 217 of its approval violations executed while the request was pending and 130 without a request. Under the guard those actions wait for the human's answer or are refused, and the roles do not find the compliant alternative: all 135 failures of M4 lack the public alert, 79 of them with the alert's approval refused and no fallback to a targeted notice, the rest in verification or escalation loops. The guard alone costs this model 9 points of success (-0.09 $[-0.15, -0.03]$, Holm $p = 0.32$), the guard with the rules in the prompt 14 ($p = 0.005$), 1.7 steps and 5.2k tokens; the rules in the prompt make its roles ask more, 1.33 requests per incident in M2 against 1.05 under the guard alone, and more refusals follow. Governance-adjusted utility is highest in M3 for this model (0.84; M4 0.79, M2 0.57), the one case where the rules in the prompt cost something under the guard. The cost is not the guard's but the rule's: the approvals the prompted roles skipped are what success in M2 was made of.

The governed society is not slower than one agent with every tool. Glimmer's single agent needs 8.1 steps per incident, as many as M3, because it acts once per step where the roles act in parallel (8 proposals per incident against 17), with 41% fewer tokens (25.7k against 43.5k) and half the approval requests; M2 and M4 resolve the same incidents in 4.2 steps. For gpt-oss-120b the single agent is the slower option (7.0 steps against 4.6 in M3), and for Gemma 4 E4B and Qwen3.5-122B the worst on every measure: 45% and 42% success in 12.7 steps, with 1.43 and 1.93 violations per incident. [TODO: API: tokens and steps per API model in M2 and M4, one sentence; the cost comparison across models.]

Of the requests Glimmer's roles send the human, most were not required by the rules: 64% in M2 and M4, 71% in M3.

The model asks whenever hospital access is at risk, whether or not the proposed action is the road closure the rule names; without the rules in its prompt it asks at the same rate with and without that risk (0.39 per incident). For the other three models the unnecessary share is 31 to 59% in M2 and M4 and about a third in M3, where the guard's own escalations, all of them required, make up most of the load. The human's load is therefore set as much by the model's caution as by the rule set, which is the load the trust-adaptive governor of Section III would remove.

e) ***RQ3*** *What success hides:* Success hides violations in every unguarded mode. In M2, 12% of Glimmer's successful episodes contain an executed violation, 18% of gpt-oss-120b's, 44% of Gemma 4 E4B's and 51% of Qwen3.5-122B's; without rules (M1) the shares are 46%, 63%, 68% and 70%. The incident is resolved, the trace says a rule was broken, and nothing in the final state does. Under the guard the share is zero by construction. Hidden harm appears only where a model acts without asking: in 5% of gpt-oss-120b's incidents and 7% of Gemma 4 E4B's in M1, in 2% for Gemma's single agent and 1% for its prompted roles, in 6 to 8% of Qwen3.5-122B's incidents in every unguarded mode, never for Glimmer and never under the guard. No model ever broadcast the planted false report, in any mode, where the naive deterministic roles did so in every episode that had one: all four verify a report before they repeat it (trace support coverage 0.96 to 1.00 in the role modes), and no cited evidence id was invented.

The failures themselves all end at the 16-step horizon and come from two mechanisms. The first is an *approval lockout*: a role asks the human for an approval the rules do not require, the answer is a refusal, because the human is absent or knows something the roles do not, and the role respects the refusal for the rest of the episode. For Glimmer all 18 failures of M2 and M4 are of this kind, in the same three scenarios in all three repeats, each with hospital access at risk; in one the water role writes for thirteen steps that the closure "requires human approval and the approval is denied" while the underpass stays open. gpt-oss-120b, which fails only 3% of the incidents in every role mode, locks itself out in the same three scenarios (13 of its 14 failures in M2 and M4). The guard did not cause it and cannot prevent it: a refusal binds whether the request was needed or not. The second is an *evidence loop*: a role requests evidence or verification again and again and never proposes the message or action the incident needs. For Glimmer it occurs only without the rules in the prompt, in 20 of the 25 M3 failures and 13 of the 19 M1 failures, always the communication role never sending the public alert; with the rules it sends a targeted notice in the same scenarios. For Gemma 4 E4B it occurs with the rules too and is why it fails a quarter of the incidents in M2 and M4, almost all flooded underpasses (53 of 62 and 51 of 60): the underpass is closed and the crew sent, but the communication role spends the episode asking to verify a residents' report it cannot check itself, nobody takes the forwarded request up, and the notice is never sent, although verified sensor readings it could cite are in the store.

The single agent fails in a third way: it loses track of what is done. In 20 of Glimmer's 23 failures in M0, all traffic accidents, it secures the hospital route again and again, alternating signal changes and reroutes until the horizon, and never sends the public notice; in the society the communication role sends it while the traffic role works.

f) ***RQ4*** *Robustness:* By family, Glimmer shows the pattern wherever there is something to govern: executed violations in M2 are 0.32 per incident in pollution spikes and 0.15 in flooded underpasses, the two families with active pollution zones, 0.02 in outages and zero in traffic accidents; the guard brings all four to zero. The cost of M3 is largest in flooded underpasses (10.3 steps, success 0.75), the family with the most approval and evidence rules in play, and smallest in outages (6.7 steps, success 0.97). By evidence quality, the leak through the prompt is flat for the two larger models (0.06 to 0.15 executed violations per incident for Glimmer and 0.16 to 0.24 for gpt-oss-120b across complete, partial, missing and conflicting evidence) and removed in every stratum; the guard's cost is highest when the evidence is missing at the start (9.0 steps for Glimmer and 11.0 for Gemma 4 E4B in M3), where the roles must query before they can act. The ranking of the modes does not depend on the utility weights: over the 243 weight settings, for Gemma 4 E4B M4 ranks first in 243 of 243 weight settings; the order M4, M3, M2, M1, M0 holds in 243 of them, for Glimmer M4 ranks first in 243 of 243 weight settings; the order M4, M2, M0, M3, M1 holds in 216 of them, for gpt-oss-120b M4 ranks first in 243 of 243 weight settings (in 81 of them tied with M3); the order M4, M3, M2, M0, M1 holds in 135 of them, and for Qwen3.5-122B M3 ranks first in 243 of 243 weight settings; the order M3, M4, M2, M1, M0 holds in 228 of them. The two governed modes lead for every model under every weighting; which of them leads, and what comes second, depends on the model. Size does not order the leak through the prompt: 0.96 executed violations per incident for the 4B model, 0.12 for the 30B, 0.19 for the 120B and 0.85 for the 122B that answers without reasoning; the guard brings all four to zero. Table VIII gives the sweeps over rule sets and human availability for Glimmer and Qwen3.5-122B (the lenient R1 rows are in the artifact). Under the lenient R1, which has no pollution-zone rule, neither mode attempts a violation and the guard costs only steps and requests (4.0 more steps and 0.45 more requests per incident in M3). Under the strict R3 the prompted roles still leak three pollution-zone reroutes but skip no approval: they ask for every one (1.10 requests per incident) and resolve 86% of the incidents, as many as the deterministic compliant society. The guard alone pays most under R3: 1.16 blocked attempts per incident, half of them sent to the human, 0.31 refused requests and 76% success (-0.10 $[-0.17, -0.04]$ against M2, Holm $p = 0.95$). With the human never available under R2, Glimmer's guarded society keeps its success (0.94 against 0.90 in the main run), as the deterministic one does under R2. It is the prompted roles that lose five points (0.91 against 0.96), almost all in flooded underpasses: they ask for approvals the rules do not

TABLE VIII

M2 (RULES IN PROMPTS) AND M3 (GUARD) UNDER THE STRICT RULE SET R3 AND UNDER R2 WITH THE HUMAN NEVER AVAILABLE, 80 SCENARIOS, ONE REPEAT; DENIED IS THE NUMBER OF REFUSED APPROVAL REQUESTS PER INCIDENT. THE LENIENT R1 ROWS ARE IN THE ARTIFACT.

Model	Setting	Mode	Succ.	Steps	Att. viol.	Exec. viol.	Overseer	Denied	False alert	Hidden harm
Glimmer 30B	R3 (strict)	M2	0.86	5.75	0.04	0.04	1.10	0.17	0.00	0.00
		M3	0.76	9.49	1.16	0.00	1.07	0.31	0.00	0.00
	R2, human never available	M2	0.91	4.55	0.09	0.09	0.10	0.10	0.00	0.00
		M3	0.94	8.38	0.59	0.00	0.10	0.09	0.00	0.00
Qwen3.5-122B	R3 (strict)	M2	0.94	5.31	2.38	2.38	1.50	0.42	0.00	0.16
		M3	0.65	9.53	4.59	0.00	2.64	0.90	0.00	0.00
	R2, human never available	M2	1.00	4.75	0.84	0.84	1.18	0.90	0.00	0.06
		M3	0.72	8.69	2.62	0.00	1.06	1.02	0.00	0.00

require, and the refusal stops them, the approval lockout of **RQ3**. The deterministic 50% needs R3 and an absent human together, a combination we did not run. Qwen3.5-122B, which does not wait for the human, shows the mirror image: with the human never available its prompted roles keep 100% success by acting without the answer, with 0.84 violations per incident and hidden harm in 6% of the incidents, while the guarded roles fall to 72% because every refused request binds; under R3 the prompted roles execute 2.38 violations per incident and harm hidden context in 16% of the incidents, and the guard holds violations at zero at 65% success. [TODO: API: whether the two API models show the same pattern (executed violations above zero in M2, zero in M3 and M4, the cost of M3) and where they differ from Glimmer, with the per-model rows of Table V.]

g) ***RQ5*** *Transfer to software operations:* Table IX repeats the deterministic rows in the incident response domain. The pattern is the same. Roles that ignore the rules resolve every incident in 1.2 steps and execute 1.9 violations per incident, among them an action that needed the on-call lead's approval in every second incident; 23% of their episodes post an untrue status page message, taken from a planted social-media post about a data breach, and 5% act against hidden context. Under the guard, zero executed violations, zero false notices, 4.5 steps, and 1.06 approval requests per incident, more than in the city because more remediation actions need a person. The compliant brain attempts no violation in either domain. Nothing in the guard, the metrics or the statistics was touched between the two tables.

h) Trust-adaptive governance: Figure 2 shows the trade-off under R3 with hidden context in 15% of the scenarios. The static guard puts two requests per incident on the human and resolves 86% of the incidents, with no hidden harm. Delegating every soft approval to roles that have earned trust removes the human's load, restores 100% success, and exposes the society to every hidden-context scenario: hidden harm in 16% of the episodes. Intermediate thresholds lie on the line between the two ends; the naive roles never earn enough trust for thresholds above 0.3, so for them delegation does nothing. Trust earned by compliance says nothing about what the rules do not encode, which is exactly what the human was there for. By the utility weights of Section V full delegation even scores higher (0.93 against 0.82), because fourteen points of success outweigh hidden harm in 16% of the episodes; which end of the line is better depends on what a hidden harm and an unresolved incident cost, and the figure measures the trade-off rather than recommending a point.

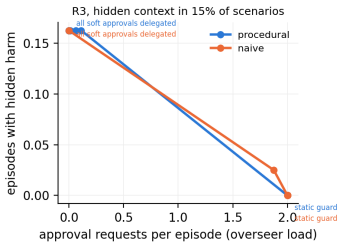


Fig. 2. Overseer load against hidden harm for static and trust-adaptive governance, rule set R3, hidden context in 15% of scenarios. Points on each line are thresholds 0.9, 0.7, 0.5, 0.3 and 0.0 from right to left; for the procedural roles the four lowest coincide.

VII. DISCUSSION

a) Prompted rules are not enforced rules: Prompting got Glimmer most of the way: without the rules the same roles broke one in every second incident, with them five of the six rules were kept in every one of 240 incidents, approvals were never skipped, and nothing untrue was broadcast. It is the remaining rule that makes the case. The pollution-zone rule is the only one whose trigger is a state flag rather than a piece of evidence or an approval, and the model, reasoning about a flooded underpass or a traffic jam, kept rerouting through the zone in one incident out of eight; the same model under the guard never did. gpt-oss-120b, four times larger, leaked through the same rule in one incident out of five, and the small Gemma 4 E4B almost once per incident: the less a model keeps of its prompt, the more of the rule keeping falls to the guard, and size alone does not say how much that is. Qwen3.5-122B, answering without reasoning, is the sharpest case: 106 times it wrote that a closure needed human approval and closed the road. A role can hold the rule and not the mechanism; the guard is the mechanism. A rule in a prompt is a consideration the model weighs against the task; a rule in

TABLE IX
DETERMINISTIC REFERENCE ROWS IN THE SOFTWARE INCIDENT RESPONSE DOMAIN, 80 SCENARIOS (20 PER FAMILY), RULE SET R2, SAME COLUMNS AS TABLE IV; THE ROWS THE TEXT DISCUSSES. SAME GUARD, TRACE SCHEMA AND METRICS CODE AS THE CITY DOMAIN.

Mode	Succ.	Steps	Prop.	Att. viol.	Exec. viol.	Miss. appr.	Overseer	TSC	False alert	Hidden harm	Silent viol.	GAU
D0 direct naive noguard	1.00	4.20	4.20	1.94	1.94	0.46	0.00	0.26	0.23	0.05	1.00	0.29
D2 roles naive noguard	1.00	1.20	4.20	1.94	1.94	0.46	0.00	0.26	0.23	0.05	1.00	0.30
D3 roles naive guard	1.00	4.53	12.31	3.76	0.00	0.00	1.06	1.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.97
D4 roles procedural noguard	1.00	4.55	11.39	0.00	0.00	0.00	1.06	1.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.97
D5 roles procedural guard	1.00	4.55	11.39	0.00	0.00	0.00	1.06	1.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.97
D6 direct procedural noguard	1.00	8.05	7.66	0.00	0.00	0.00	1.06	1.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.95

the guard is a constraint on what can execute. The two also fail differently. When a model asked for an approval the rules did not require, a refusal from an absent or better informed human cost the incident; the guard could not have prevented that, because the request was the model's own. When the guard was the only source of the rules, the roles paid to discover them, Glimmer in steps and tokens and gpt-oss-120b in requests to the human, and Glimmer's communication role, in one family, never discovered the alert it was allowed to send. The combination removes both costs where the roles can walk the compliant path: the rules in the prompt tell them where it is, the guard catches what the prompt did not prevent, and the trace records what each one did. Where they cannot, as Qwen3.5-122B could not when an alert's approval was refused, the guard turns a hidden violation into a visible failure; the trace then shows whether to change the model, the fallback or the rule, which no outcome measure could. For an engineer the recommendation is plain: write the rules once, give them to the roles as text and to the guard as data, and read the trace, not the outcome, to find out which of the two did the work. A new system needs four artefacts for this, an action catalogue with risk levels and evidence topics, the rule set as data, roles with their visibility and the trace schema; guard, metrics and statistics do not change.[TODO: API: one clause on whether the API models leaked the same rule or a different one.]

b) One agent or a society: One agent with every tool is not the cheaper alternative. For Glimmer and gpt-oss-120b it kept the rules about as well as the prompted society, but it acts once per step: Glimmer's single agent, in one traffic accident out of three, kept securing a route that was already secure while the public notice waited, and gpt-oss-120b's needed half as many steps again as the governed society; for the other two models it was the worst configuration on every measure. The society's roles act at once, and the guard is what keeps that parallelism within the rules.

c) The human is not a rule: The approval step looks like a bottleneck and, under strict rules and an unavailable human, it is: success drops to a half. The adaptive governor shows what removing it costs: the rules capture what the designers foresaw, the human catches the rest, and compliance with the rules does not predict the rest. To reduce human load, reduce the *unnecessary* share of approval requests, which the trace measures, rather than delegate on trust.

d) Threats to validity: Construct: the testbed is symbolic and its rules are ours; hidden context is a coin flip with a fixed rate, and its harm is binary. The metrics measure conformance to the given rules, not the quality of the rules. *Internal*: the naive roles' reactions to the guard were written by us; a different reactive policy would change the cost side, not the violation side. LLM nondeterminism is handled by repeats and paired tests; prompts are fixed and published, and were not tuned per model, so the small model's evidence loops bound what an untuned prompt achieves rather than what the model can do. *External*: two domains that we built to correspond, four open-weight models at one sampling setting each[TODO: API: "and two API models from one provider"], a deterministic human. The model that leaked approvals is also the one run without reasoning; whether that is the model or the missing reasoning is not separated here. The framework transfers when the four artefacts can be written; whether the numbers transfer is an open question. *Conclusion*: all comparisons are paired, corrected for multiple testing and reported with intervals; seeds, scenario sets and manifests are in the artifact.

VIII. CONCLUSION

Governed agent societies put the rules where the actions are: in a guard inside the transition function that checks provenance, asks a person when the rules say so, and leaves a trace of everything it decided. With four LLMs driving the roles, the rules in the prompt still leaked between one violation per eight incidents and one per incident, for the reasoning models through one rule, for the model that answers directly through the approvals it marked as required and did not wait for; the guard removed every one, at no cost once reasoning roles knew the rules, at a price in steps or human requests when they did not, and at the price of the skipped approvals for the model that had succeeded by skipping them. Success and governance are different things: up to two thirds of the successful incidents of ungoverned roles hid a violation, and the only harms came from acting without asking a person. Next are LLM roles in the second domain and role policies learned from the traces the guard produces. Testbed, rule sets, prompts, scenario sets, JSONL traces, statistics scripts and a one-command reproduction of every table are available at [TODO: anonymous link]; every reported number carries a manifest with code version, seed and configuration.

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